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Abstract

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1 Introduction

[This is only a skeleton of the intro] Much of the world knowledge can be expressed in terms of relations, but oftentimes such relations are graded, implied, and nonliteral. Such kind of implicit inference of event relations is common in human language processing... (cite) Talk about eliciture and why its implied relationships between any two events are non-mandated. (cite)

Previous studies have attempted to show how LMs can build a world model through pragmatic inference... (cite) To the best of our knowledge, Pan & Kehler is the only work that examines LM's ability to perform eliciture inference. They demonstrate that LMs not only draw eliciture but also leverage eliciture to guide downstream sentential processing. we aim to extend on their findings by evaluating models of different families and studying the internal representations of implicit causal inference.

The benefits of understanding elicitors in LMs are multifold: 1. whether LMs–trained with distributional objective–demonstrate human-like nonliteral inference in non-mandated setting 2. more comprehensive views into how LMs build an internal world model 3. Potentially understand the implicit bias in LMs, which has implications in safety and alignment

To these aims, we explore three main questions:

RQ1 *Do model behaviors reflect inferences about implicit causal relationships within sentences?*
RQ2 *Do LMs form internal representations of implicit causal relationships?*
RQ3 *If **RQ2** is true, do representations of implicit causality generalize to naturalistic settings with potential real-world implications?*

Our contribution is...

2 Background

3 Experiments

3.1 Measuring Implicit Causal Inference through Model Behaviors

Models. In this and all of the following experiments, we test Gemma 2 2B/9B [Gemma Team, 2024], Qwen3 4B/8B [Qwen Team, 2025], Llama 3.2 3B [Meta AI, 2024], and Llama 3 8B [Dubey et al., 2024] base checkpoints.

Dataset. We use 150 manually authored pairs of sentences. In each pair, the modifier or relative clause in the critical sentence provides a plausible cause of that outcome based on physical or everyday world knowledge; in the *control* sentence, it provides an incidental detail. The dataset generally follows the format of [person] [modifier content] [outcome]. For example, *The executive who falsified*

Submitted to 40th Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS 2026). Do not distribute.

quarterly revenue figures was fired is paired with *The executive who wore a blue silk tie was fired*. This dataset extends the no-context eliciture paradigm of Pan and Kehler [2025], which tests whether an apparently descriptive modifier is nevertheless understood as an explanation.

Yes/No. We first present the sentences of [person] [modifier content] [outcome] as context and then ask, "Does [modifier content] explain why [outcome]?" We compute the probabilities of the complete answers *Yes* and *No*, including capitalization variants, and normalize them to obtain $P(\text{Yes})$.

7-point Likert. We present the tested sentences as context and then ask how strongly the [modifier content] explains the [outcome] on a scale from 1 (definitely not) through 4 (uncertain) to 7 (definitely yes). We compute a probability for each of the seven complete answers and use their probability-weighted mean as the model's rating.

Surprisal. Following Pan and Kehler [2025], we remove the sentence-final period and append *", and I don't know why."* We use the surprisal of this continuation as the score. The intuition is that if the modifier has already supplied an explanation, subsequently claiming *I don't know why* should be less expected and therefore more surprising.

For all three measures, paired accuracy is the proportion of pairs in which the critical sentence scores strictly above its control; chance is .5, ties count as incorrect.

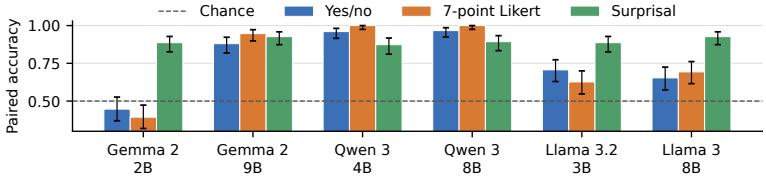


Figure 1: Paired accuracy of model judgments on implicit causal inference items, comparing Yes/No prompting, 7-point likert rating, and the surprisal of the continuation *", and I don't know why."* Higher accuracy indicates better performance in implicit causality inferences.

Results. As shown in figure 1, models demonstrate implicit causal inference most consistently through surprisals. Not all models can faithfully report their implicit causal inference through Yes/No and 7-Point Likert rating, and the performance of such metalinguistic causal inference increases with model size.

3.2 Identifying Internal Representations of Implicit Causality Inference

Given that LMs behaviorally demonstrate implicit causal inference, do LMs form internal representations of implicit causality? Specifically, we ask two questions:

1) Do model activations distinguish implicit causal relationships from other relations? If a representation is specific to causality, a causal direction should separate causal pairs well but transfer less reliably to temporal or plausibility pairs.

2) If such representations exist, could the representations of cross-sentence implicit causality transfer to within-sentence causality (eliciture)? Within-sentence causal inferences are less strong and more optional compared to cross-sentence causal inferences. If the representations of implicit causality inference is robutst, it should transfer across syntactic variations.

Datasets. We use three datasets of matched critical/control pairs:

1) *Causal*: This dataset tests whether models represent implicit causal relationships across different sentence structures. We construct the cross-sentence items using the same critical/control logic as the within-sentence eliciture items in Section 3.1, which extend Pan and Kehler [2025]. The dataset contains 630 pairs in total. The training set contains 384 cross-sentence pairs, and the in-distribution (ID) test set contains 96 unseen cross-sentence pairs. The out-of-distribution (OOD) test set contains the 150 unseen within-sentence pairs from Section 3.1. Thus, the ID test changes the scenarios, whereas the OOD test also changes the sentence structure. For example, *Anika avoided the Amber Cafe. The Amber Cafe repeatedly mixed up Anika's allergy order* is the critical item; replacing the second sentence with *The Amber Cafe had a copper sign* creates the control.

2) *Temporal*: This dataset tests whether an event is compatible with a typical occasion for an occupation. We construct it as a non-causal control using the same critical/control format. We use 1,000 pairs in total: 800 for training and 200 for ID testing. For example, the critical item describes a lifeguard getting a sunburn, whereas the control describes a translator getting the same sunburn. This dataset measures occasion compatibility, not temporal order.

3) *Plausibility*: This dataset tests whether models distinguish probable events from physically impossible events. We adapt the probable–impossible pairs from Hu et al. [2025], following Lepori et al. [2026]. The dataset contains 70 pairs in total: 56 for training and 14 for ID testing. For example, the critical item describes someone baking a cake in an oven, whereas the control replaces the oven with a freezer.

CAA directions. Contrastive Activation Addition (CAA) represents a relation with a direction in a model's activation space [Rimsky et al., 2024]. At each tested layer, we subtract the final-token activation of every control item from that of its matched critical item, then average these differences over the training pairs. An evaluation item receives a scalar score by projection onto this direction of averaged difference; paired accuracy is the proportion of evaluation pairs for which the critical item scores higher.

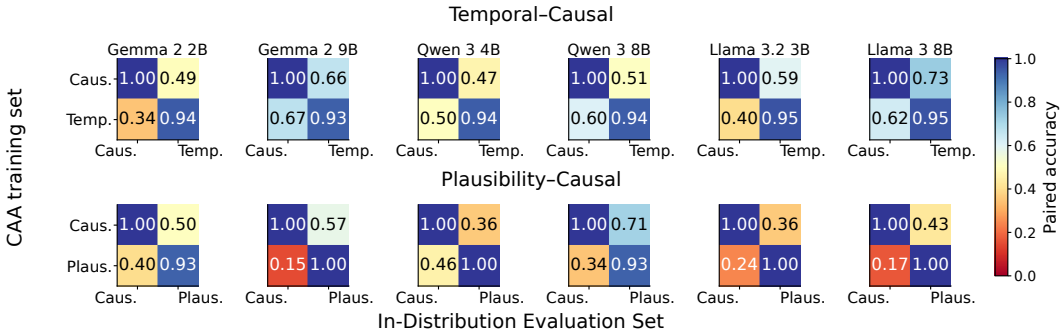


Figure 2: Cross-transfer paired accuracy between causal and temporal relations (top row) and causal and plausibility relations (bottom row). Within each heatmap, rows show the CAA training set and columns show the in-distribution evaluation set. **Causal CAA directions are largely relation-selective and distinct from temporal and plausibility directions.**

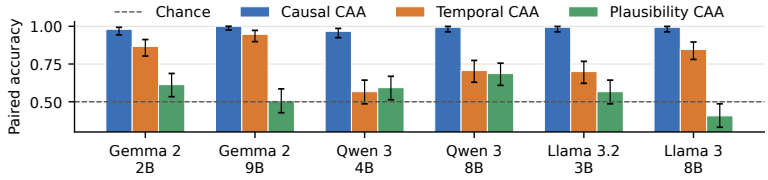


Figure 3: Paired accuracy of causal, temporal, and plausibility CAA directions on 150 unseen within-sentence causal inference pairs with 95% CIs. **Causal CAA directions generalize consistently to within-sentence implicit causal inference.** Temporal and plausibility CAA directions transfer less consistently to within-sentence implicit causal items.

Results.

3.3 Generalization to Naturalistic Scenarios

Dataset.

Table 1: Mean paired differences in causal CAA projection in naturalistic causal scenarios. Positive values indicate that a demographic group has a greater mean projection than the white-male condition. Bolded values indicate statsitically significant difference from the white-male projection scores. **Demographic descriptions are associated with differences in causal CAA projections.** Minority females generally have larger projection raw mean scores than minority males along the implicit causal directions.

	Gemma 2 2B	Gemma 2 9B	Qwen3 4B	Qwen3 8B	Llama 3.2 3B	Llama 3 8B
Minority male − White male	**.41 ± .32**	**1.9 ± .40**	.073 ± .093	**.29 ± .17**	.025 ± .029	**.030 ± .020**
Minority female − White male	**.57 ± .32**	**2.3 ± .41**	**.15 ± .10**	**.39 ± .15**	**.069 ± .033**	**.060 ± .021**

Results.

4 Discussion

References

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A Raw CAA Projection Distributions

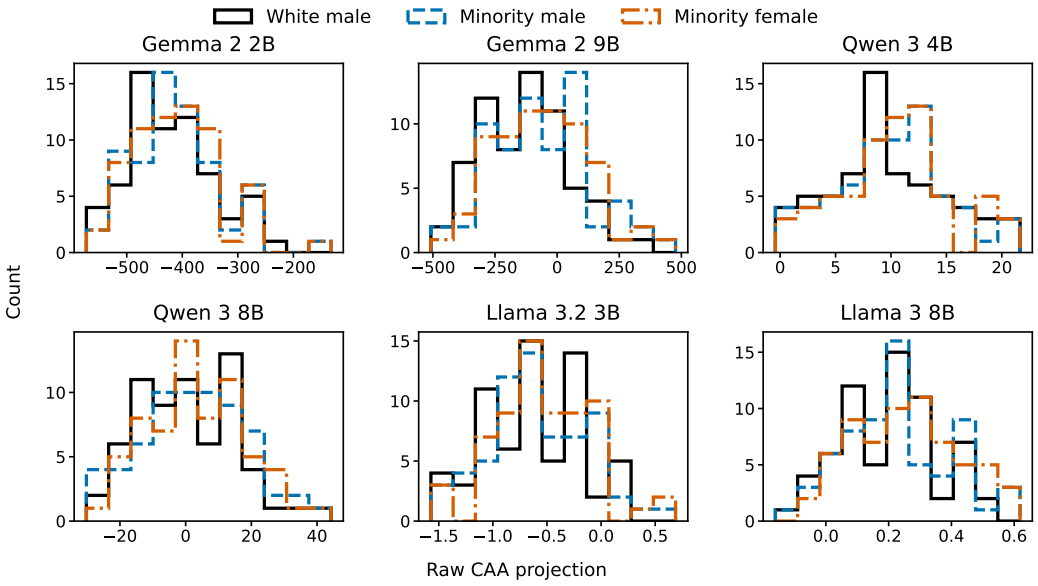


Figure 4: Raw causal CAA projection distributions for three matched demographic conditions across 65 scenarios per model. **The three conditions have substantially overlapping projection distributions in every model.** Colors and line styles distinguish the White-male, minority-male, and minority-female conditions.